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MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



PEOPLE

MULTICULTURAL TEAMS: MAPPING THE DIFFERENCES

Erin Meyer's eight scales, Albania and Germany in GLOBE, what its managers call practice and what they would prefer, a meta-analysis of 10,632 teams, a scale for cultural intelligence and a card for team norms.

10,632 teams in 108 studies: cultural diversity brought more creativity and satisfaction, but also more task conflict and less cohesion.

STAHL ET AL., 2010

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More and more teams bring together people who grew up in different countries. The differences that hurt are rarely the visible ones; they lie in how people criticise, disagree, decide and keep time. These pages map them, without turning a country's score into a judgement about a person.

Erin Meyer places countries on eight scales and warns that a position means something only next to another. GLOBE asked managers in 62 societies how things are and how they should be; Albania's managers describe more loyalty to the group than West Germany's, and less planning for the future. Hofstede's own data hold only two scores for Albania. A meta-analysis of 10,632 teams finds diversity to be both an asset and a liability. A scale for cultural intelligence measures a person, and a card helps a team agree its norms.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editors interpret rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

It depends where you stand

In 2014 Erin Meyer of INSEAD set out the Culture Map, in Harvard Business Review and in a book: eight scales on which cultural gaps most often open.

01
Communicating
explicit and literal, or layered and implied

02
Evaluating
frank or diplomatic negative feedback

03
Persuading
principles first, or applications first

04
Leading
egalitarian or hierarchical

05
Deciding
by consensus or from the top

06
Trusting
built through the task or the relationship

07
Disagreeing
open confrontation seen as useful, or as harmful

08
Scheduling
a linear plan, or a flexible one

In Amsterdam a Mexican director found his Dutch team ignoring his authority; in Monterrey a Chinese manager found the Mexicans egalitarian. On Leading, Mexico sits between the two, so both were right.

“What matters is the position of one country relative to another.”

Source: Erin Meyer, Harvard Business Review, 2014

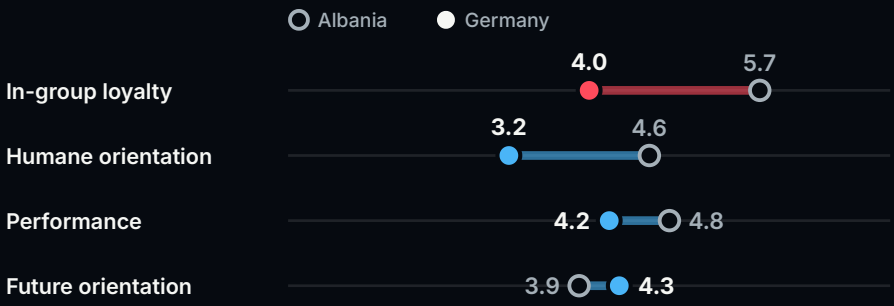
The two managers are Meyer's examples; she does not give their real names. The profiles describe a society at large, she writes, not every person in it. The editors have condensed the descriptions of the scales.

THE NUMBERS

Albania and Germany, side by side

In the GLOBE study (next page), middle managers rated how things are in their society, from 1 to 7. Here are Albania and the West German sample on four of its nine dimensions, from the 2004 data:

GLOBE PRACTICES, 1 TO 7



Hofstede's own data (2015) hold only two of his six scores for Albania, on a scale to 100: long-term orientation 61, against Germany's 83, and indulgence 15, against 40. His site advises taking dimension scores “with a grain of salt”.

OUR READING

The chart describes two countries, not your two colleagues.

Sources: Robert J. House, Paul J. Hanges, Mansour Javidan, Peter W. Dorfman & Vipin Gupta (eds.), Sage, 2004 (via GLOBE Project, society-level data, 2004); Geert Hofstede, 2015

Rounded averages of managers' answers; they do not describe individuals. “In-group loyalty” is GLOBE's in-group collectivism. Other Hofstede scores for Albania found online cite no published study, so we leave them out.

More in the essay From Albania to Germany: what I have changed in the way I lead

THE MODEL

What is done, what should be

The GLOBE study, founded by Robert House, asked more than 17,000 middle managers in 62 societies about nine dimensions of culture, twice over: how things are in their society, and how they should be. Albania was one of the 62.

GLOBE SCORES FROM 1 TO 7, PRACTICES AND VALUES



GLOBE counts power distance among the dimensions nobody wants: managers in both countries would like less of it. On rules, GLOBE's uncertainty avoidance, they part ways: the Albanian managers want more, the German managers fewer.

OUR READING

What managers say is done and what they say should be done make two different maps. In a mixed team, ask about both.

Source: Robert J. House, Paul J. Hanges, Mansour Javidan, Peter W. Dorfman & Vipin Gupta (eds.), Sage, 2004 (via GLOBE Project, society-level data, 2004)

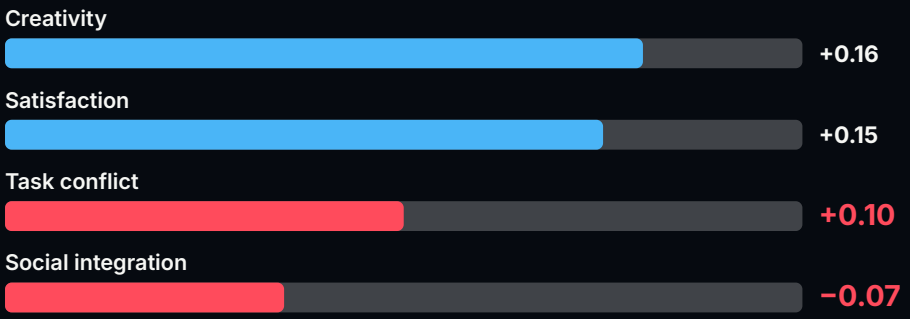
Scores rounded from GLOBE's society-level data (2004); Germany is the West German sample. They average managers' answers and do not speak for every person.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Asset and liability

Günter Stahl, Martha Maznevski, Andreas Voigt and Karsten Jonsen pooled 108 studies of 10,632 teams. Cultural diversity had no direct link with team performance; instead it pulled the way teams work in two directions.

AVERAGE CORRELATION WITH CULTURAL DIVERSITY



Context changed the picture. Diverse teams had more conflict when the task was complex, when they worked in one place rather than apart and, against the authors' hypothesis, when they had been together longer. In larger teams, communication suffered.

OUR READING

Closing the gaps takes more than time: someone has to name them and agree how the team will work.

Source: Günter K. Stahl, Martha L. Maznevski, Andreas Voigt & Karsten Jonsen, Journal of International Business Studies 41(4), 2010

Weighted mean correlations, small by the usual standard; creativity rests on only 5 effect sizes, social integration on 22. The authors' own summary: diversity “can be both an asset and a liability”.

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Measure the person, not the passport

Soon Ang, Linn Van Dyne and colleagues built a 20-item scale for cultural intelligence (CQ), the capability to work effectively in culturally diverse settings. Each statement is rated from 1 to 7. They tested it on 1,360 people, then in three studies with 794 people in the USA and Singapore.

01
Metacognitive
checking what you think you know about a culture while you deal with it

02
Cognitive
knowing values, languages and the rules of gesture elsewhere

03
Motivational
enjoying contact and trusting yourself to adjust

04
Behavioural
changing pace, pauses and gestures when the situation needs it

Each part predicted something different. The first two predicted cultural judgement and decisions; the last two, adjustment to a new culture; the first and the last, task performance.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, A CHECK AFTER MEETINGS

Method	each member writes the decision and the next step in one line
Six meetings	21 of 30 lines matched

The gap shows where a “yes” meant “I heard you”. The figures are made up.

Source: Soon Ang, Linn Van Dyne, Christine Koh, K. Yee Ng, Klaus J. Templer, Cheryl Tay & N. Anand Chandrasekar, Management and Organization Review 3(3), 2007

Unlike the country scores on the earlier pages, CQ is one person's assessment of themselves. The item summaries and the meeting check are the editors'.

More in the essay Teams with many languages and many countries

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The team norms card

Jeanne Brett, Kristin Behfar and Mary Kern found that the most successful multicultural teams they studied adapted, changed the team's shape, had a manager set norms early and let someone leave only as a last resort. One manager told the members they had been chosen for their expertise, not their English. Fill in the card together in the first week.

01 Working language which one, and what is always put in writing

02 Saying something is wrong in private or in the group, how direct

03 Disagreeing how to disagree in a meeting; who asks the quiet ones

04 Deciding who decides what, and when a decision counts as made

05 Time what “on time” and “deadline” mean here

06 Checking understanding show me how you would do it, not “did you understand?”

Sources: Jeanne Brett, Kristin Behfar & Mary C. Kern, Harvard Business Review, 2006; Erin Meyer, Harvard Business Review, 2014

A practice the editors propose, drawing on the managerial intervention in Brett, Behfar and Kern and on Meyer's eight scales. Revisit it whenever someone joins the team.

Open the tool: Shift Handover stivencatalyst.com/tools/shift-handover/

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

Navigating the Cultural Minefield
Erin Meyer, Harvard Business Review, 2014
https://hbr.org/2014/05/navigating-the-cultural-minefield

Culture, Leadership, and Organizations: The GLOBE Study of 62 Societies
Robert J. House, Paul J. Hanges, Mansour Javidan, Peter W. Dorfman & Vipin Gupta (eds.), Sage, 2004 · via GLOBE Project, society-level data, 2004
https://globeproject.com/study_2004_2007

Dimension data matrix: six dimensions as in Cultures and Organizations, 3rd ed. (version 2015 12 08)
Geert Hofstede, 2015
https://geerthofstede.com/research-and-vsm/dimension-data-matrix/

Unraveling the effects of cultural diversity in teams: A meta-analysis of research on multicultural work groups
Günter K. Stahl, Martha L. Maznevski, Andreas Voigt & Karsten Jonsen, Journal of International Business Studies 41(4), 2010
https://doi.org/10.1057/jibs.2009.85

Cultural Intelligence: Its Measurement and Effects on Cultural Judgment and Decision Making, Cultural Adaptation and Task Performance
Soon Ang, Linn Van Dyne, Christine Koh, K. Yee Ng, Klaus J. Templer, Cheryl Tay & N. Anand Chandrasekar, Management and Organization Review 3(3), 2007
https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1740-8784.2007.00082.x

Managing Multicultural Teams
Jeanne Brett, Kristin Behfar & Mary C. Kern, Harvard Business Review, 2006
https://hbr.org/2006/11/managing-multicultural-teams

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what exactly it measures. Where the publisher's page could not be opened, the figure was checked against independent summaries and is marked “via”. The editors' interpretation is marked “Our reading”. Figures that could not be confirmed are not in the issue.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

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Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

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